MERIDIAN INTELLIGENCE

Independent Strategic Assessment

Is There a Global Business in What You Do?

A verified read on the market, the field, and where a strong business could sit.

Prepared for Mike Molloy | An independent assessment by Meridian Intelligence | July 2026 | Private and confidential

About this assessment. This is an independent read prepared by Meridian Intelligence, in response to the question of whether there is a global opportunity to build a strong business here. It assesses that opportunity for you as an individual, not for any one company. A current platform is referenced where useful, but nothing here assumes it is the vehicle; that is yours to decide, and one of the questions at the end. Where a claim is made about the market or the field, it has been checked and verified, so it can be relied on.

01 · THE SHORT ANSWER

The market is not the question. Focus and proof are.

The global market for senior geopolitical and international-business advisory is real, and it is growing. Demand is not the difficulty. The field is, and so is the work of turning what you have into something a client can readily buy.

The generalist version of this sits in a lane already held by some of the most established names in the business. The version that could become genuinely strong for you is narrower and sharper, and it rests on one asset almost none of them can claim, provided it is as real and as current as it appears from the outside: your standing with the Church and the Holy See, set alongside State and capital.

So the work ahead is choosing the vehicle, narrowing the focus, and evidencing the track record. It is not finding demand.

02 · THE DEMAND

Serious people now pay to read a fragmenting world, and that is verified.

This is not a hopeful claim. Boards, investors and institutions increasingly treat geopolitics as a core driver of value rather than background noise, and the major governance and consulting houses, among them EY, BCG, KPMG and Deloitte, have all published work through late 2025 and into 2026 documenting that shift. When the cost of being wrong rises, people pay for judgement.

The buyers are identifiable and they have budgets: multinational corporations, financial institutions and investors, and government and institutional bodies. That is the established client base for this kind of advice, and it is widening as sanctions, supply-chain politics and shifting alliances make the world harder to read.

So this is not a question of whether anyone wants what such a business would offer. They do, and demonstrably so. The question is why they would choose it over the firms that already hold the shelf.

03 · THE FIELD

The competition is built on precisely the same pitch.

At the institutional end sit the scaled research and consulting houses, firms like Eurasia Group and Control Risks, who win on coverage, brand and headcount. Competing with them on scale is not the path.

The closest comparison is the access-led advisories: Kissinger Associates, The Cohen Group, Hakluyt, Teneo, McLarty Associates. Their entire model is senior relationships and the ability to open doors others cannot, sold to a small, select client base on substantial retainers. It is a proven, high-margin business, and it is very much alive. Hakluyt, for example, appointed a former United Kingdom national security adviser to its board as recently as January 2026. These are serious, well-connected operators with long track records.

That sets the real test. A client weighing a new general geopolitical adviser is implicitly comparing them to these firms, and against that comparison access alone is not enough, because access is what they sell too. The winning proposition needs a reason to be chosen that they cannot easily match.

04 · THE EDGE

The distinctive asset is the one lane the larger firms cannot credibly enter.

In Meridian's assessment, this is where the strong business sits. The edge is not geopolitical risk in general, which is crowded. It is the intersection of the Church and the Holy See with State and with capital. Almost nobody offers credible, senior faith-institutional access as a commercial advisory, and it cannot be manufactured or hired in quickly. It is earned over years.

One honest note, and it is the reason this is framed as a strength rather than a fact. The value of that access depends on it being live and activatable today. If it is as current as it appears, it is close to unique and genuinely defensible. That is a matter only you can confirm, and it sits among the questions at the end.

Assuming it holds, the prize is real. The Church is one of the largest institutional and asset-holding networks on earth, and the philanthropic, investment and diplomatic world around it is vast and strikingly under-served by advisers who truly understand it. A person who can move credibly between the Holy See, European statecraft and serious capital is close to one of one.

Meridian's recommendation: rather than compete as a generalist against firms like Hakluyt, build around the axis you already own, where the market cannot easily replace you. Narrowing there moves the proposition from one of many to one of one.

05 · FROM ACCESS TO A BUSINESS

Access is a network. It is not yet a business, and the vehicle is a choice.

The first real decision is what form this takes. It could be a solo advisory practice trading on a name, a small firm, a productised service, or a partnership that supplies an engine rather than building one alone. Each is a different life and a different business, and that choice comes before everything else.

Whichever it is, the same shift has to happen. At present the offer is who you know. A business is defined by what a client can buy, how often, and what they reliably receive for the money. Until access becomes a repeatable, sellable thing, it remains a network, and networks do not compound into value the way products do.

There are several ways to productise it, and a strong business would choose a small number rather than all: a retained advisory relationship at a fixed fee, a private intelligence or briefing service on a set cadence, deal origination and introductions carried on a success fee tied to outcomes, and commissioned assessments on specific high-stakes questions. The point is not the menu. It is that each is a unit a client can buy again, which access on its own never is.

There is also a delivery question worth noting, because it shapes the economics. A business of this kind scales when an engine carries the gathering, monitoring and verification, leaving the principal's judgement and access at the centre where they belong. That is how a single senior operator produces something repeatable rather than selling only their own hours.

06 · WHAT WOULD MAKE IT STRONG

Five moves turn this from a question into a business.

1. Choose the vehicle, then focus on one spine. Decide what form this takes, and settle on the single proposition that is the business. With several ventures currently in play at once, concentrating on one will make the offer far stronger and easier for a client to grasp; the others can feed it or wait.
2. Productise the offer. Turn access into two or three things a client can buy repeatedly, priced and described plainly. A network becomes a company at exactly this step.
3. Evidence the track record. Relationships open the first meeting; demonstrated outcomes win the second. Assembling named results, in summary or under NDA, will carry real weight.
4. Choose the buyer and the geography. Decide who writes the first cheque and where to build from. A focused proposition to one clear buyer beats a broad one to everyone.
5. Consider a delivery engine. An AI-native, human-led layer keeps the product repeatable and scalable rather than capped by the principal’s own hours. This is where real enterprise value is created.

07 · OPEN QUESTIONS

Answering these turns the assessment into a plan.

This has been written from the outside. These are the things only you can answer, and each one materially sharpens what comes next.

1. What do you want to build? A solo practice, a firm, a product, or a partnership? The whole plan follows from this.
2. Is the access live? Is your standing with the Church and the Holy See current and activatable now? This is the point the strongest version turns on.
3. What does a client buy today? Concretely, what have clients paid for, and what did it cost them?
4. What can be pointed to? What outcomes can be evidenced, even in summary or under NDA, that show the value of the involvement?
5. Where is the focus? Of everything currently in play, which one is the business to build, and which are feeders or best set aside?
6. Who is the first buyer, and where? Corporates, funds, family offices, institutions, or the Church itself, and in which geography to start?

The market is there, and it has been verified. The generalist path is hard. The focused business, built on what only you have, could be genuinely strong. That is the whole of it.